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Culture (OWC): [Zulu \(FX20\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1951

Coverage Date: 1800-1951

Place Coverage

Makhanya tribe, Umbumbulu township, Umlazi District, KwaZulu-Natal Province, South Africa

Section Title(S): Father's Brother's Wife

The *mamekazi* is particularly interested in her sister's childbirth and in the pre- and post-natal obligations attached to it. From time to time she will cook for her sister's children, and will help the sister to weed her fields. Even if she lives far away, the children can be sent to stay with her for a few days. When near at hand, she helps to brew beer for the wedding of sister's sons, and will in any case come to the ceremony with presents.

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The special term for this relative would appear to indicate that while she is outside the descent group into which her sister has married, she is drawn into its sphere in a mother role. Classification of the husband's mother's sister with the mother's sister is the usual indication in this system of identification of a wife with her husband's kinship attitudes.

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Mother's Brother
Husband's Mother's Brother } *malume*

Reciprocals: Sister's child
Sister's son's wife

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Like the class of father's brothers, the mother's brothers are divided into the eldest, the *umalume omkhulu* (great mother's brother) and the others who are described as *umalume omncane* (little mother's brother). In this case the division implies an intensification of maternal obligation centred about the great *malume*.

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As with the *mamekazi*, the *malume* (male mother) shares in the gentle protective attitude of the mother whose brother he is. Being a man, however, he is usually in a position to contribute more materially to the welfare of his sister's children. As a disciplinarian, he can be appealed to by his sister only if the children's father's brothers and sisters are not at hand. Indeed, a child may seek refuge with a nearby *malume* if he has been severely scolded at home. This *malume* might speak to the parents on the child's behalf, or at worst would scold him more mildly than his parents had done.

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Since he is of the next ascending generation, the *malume* must be respected by his sister's children, and there is no question of a joking relationship or of undue familiarity. Nevertheless, the relationship is one of great kindness, and a man may always turn to his *malume* for sympathy and help when he is in need.

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The mother's brother appears at his sister's kraal soon after she has given birth, bringing with him food, money or other presents. If he omits to fulfil this obligation and the child should cry when he is visiting the kraal, those present will call '*mkhunge*' (surround him with gifts, give him something in the customary way). The *malume* will then give money for the child or arrange for a goat to be slaughtered for it,  142 according to his means. Babies may be seen wearing one or more goatskin bracelets, each of which indicates that a goat has been killed in this way.

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